## Like-minded thinkers

Clements was not the only one thinking along these lines. Zoologist Victor Shelford was working toward the same idea. The pair began to meet over the next 20 years, while pursuing their own research, to see how they could combine the worlds of plants and animals. Clements studied plant biomes in Colorado with his wife, the eminent botanist Edith Clements. Meanwhile, Shelford compiled the *Naturalist's Guide to the Americas* (1926)—the first major geographical summary of wildlife in the Americas, in which he talked about "biota." This book laid much of the foundation for later findings.

Ways of looking at interactions in ecological communities took a major step forward when British botanist Arthur Tansley introduced the term "ecosystem" in 1935. When Clements and Shelford published the results of their collaboration in 1939, they were not making a sudden breakthrough—rather it was a consolidation of ideas that had been taking shape over a long time.

The collaboration between botany and zoology was crucial. Only by looking at the totality of the natural world with its dynamic interactions could scientists hope to get a full picture, and Clements defined a biome as "an organic unit comprising all the species of plants and animals at home in a particular habitat." Even so, biomes have come to be defined principally by vegetation type.

The most important feature of biomes is that they link vegetation and plant communities across the world. There are tropical forests, for example, in every continent, but most tree species appear only in one continent. So, the range of trees within the Amazonian forests is completely different from the range of trees in the forests of Indonesia. Yet both areas are identifiable as tropical forest, because the trees have features in common.